



How We Tested

We tested e-mail server software to see how well they could serve a SoHo organisation that typically has around 25 nodes with traffic of around 200 to 500 e-mails per day. Here, performance was not a big issue, but bundled features played an important role. We didn't put a premium on performance, because it depends on factors such as the ISP, bandwidth, ISP traffic, time of day (peak/off-peak time), and traffic on the external server. These factors never remain constant.

We used a Sify dial-up account. Prior to the test, we loaded our test systems with Windows XP and kept a Norton Ghost image handy. A couple of e-mail IDs with test e-mails were set up.

A backup e-mail ID had a duplicate set of these so that when the server downloads an e-mail without the 'Leave on Server' feature, you can transfer the test e-mails back, and test the next server software.

One e-mail ID held nine e-mails, some of which had attachments. The other e-mail ID held all the 22 virus test messages. Here, we used an external mail server that did not have anti-virus software installed.

Another pre-requisite was that a DNS MX record, consisting of a domain name and its associated IP address, had to be created on the local DNS server. The DNS entry pointed the domain to the IP address of the server. For these tests, the domain was **mailtest.jdm.co.in** and the IP address was **192.168.0.1**.

Performance

The performance tests comprised the speed test, the virus test and the flooding test.

The speed test and virus test downloaded e-mails from a server on the Internet to our local server. The speed test consisted of the downloading of a set of nine e-mails that amounted to 11 MB; Eight of them had attachments sized 2 MB.

In the virus test, we downloaded 22 e-mails, each with an EICAR virus string in a different format. The mail server software might not detect all the viruses, though it might catch all of the infected e-mails. However, if it does not detect at least a few, then it's not quite a secure fortress.

Lastly, the flooding test determined the stability of the e-mail server under heavy load. We pumped in 1,000 e-mails to the SMTP port, and checked whether it crashed. It didn't; rather, it stopped responding to new connections after accepting a certain number of messages. We noted down this number.

During testing, we installed each new software after restoring the image of the primary partition. We then configured the server to download e-mails for the speed test, and noted down the time taken. Next, we configured it to download virus-infected e-mails, and noted down the number of viruses caught by the anti-virus. Finally, we stressed the SMTP server with the flooding test.

Features

The features we looked for were divided into three categories: basic e-mailing, interface, and security.

The basic e-mailing category included features such as downloading of mails from an external server via POP3, forwarding, archiving, sorting, auto-carbon copy and auto-reply.

The interface category comprised features such as prioritising users, specifying user quota and support for multiple domains, multiple users, multiple aliases, and multiple mailing lists. It's a must for an e-mail software to provide the administrator with rights to restrict the maximum message size. These days, most software come with browser-based mail and admin interfaces, so these are also important. An inbuilt dialler reduces the trouble of setting up and integrating a Windows dialler, and eases the scheduling process. These features, too, were included in this category, and we checked whether the software had them.

The security category included features such as integrated anti-virus and anti-spam support. Here, we checked whether the software used a hostname-based, as well as IP-based screening method to restrict unauthorised users. We also verified whether the SMTP server supported features such as relay ON/OFF, SMTP authentication and POP3-before-SMTP. Lastly, we checked for Secure Socket Layer (SSL) support.

We also checked for ease of use depending on how intuitive and user-friendly the software was.

the message size. Support for anti-virus and anti-spam is missing. It also lacks SSL support and hostname-based screening.

You might find climbing a Himalayan mountain easier than uninstalling CommuniGate Pro! It doesn't pack in an uninstaller, nor does Windows provide a method to uninstall it.

In sum, CommuniGate Pro has all the features a typical system administrator would like to have at hand for a SoHo environment, but finding your way about might take some time.

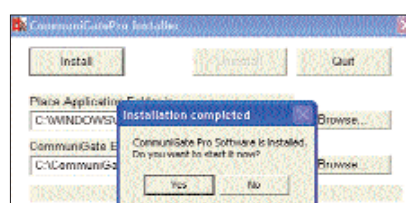
Price: NA

Web site:

www.stalker.com/CommuniGatePro

+ Flow control

- No remote dialler; no uninstall facility



After installation, CommuniGate Pro prompts the user to start the server

CommuniGate Pro	B+
Performance	■■■■■
Features	■■■■■
Ease of use	■■■■■

IMail Express

Online always

As compared to CommuniGate Pro, IMail takes longer to install. As it configures the domain for the server, helps you to create accounts on the server, lets you enable or disable servers that should start by default when Windows boots up, and sets the default relay option for the SMTP server. It even installs the default SSL key. It also creates the LDAP database, which can't be skipped.

The downside for a dial-up user: IMail can-



During installation, IMail lists the servers that are present, while the user has to select the ones that should start